

PRINCIPLES OF EFFECTIVE CPD

A Practical Guide to Leading Better Teaching

By Adam Boxer and Ben Rice



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INTRODUCTION

by Adam Boxer & Ben Rice



If we create a culture where every teacher believes they need to improve, not because they are not good enough, but because they can be even better, there is no limit to what we can achieve.

Professor Dylan Wiliam

TES: Teaching is not a research-based profession.¹



As a profession, we have invested heavily in CPD. Most schools will have extensive programmes of development, featuring INSET days, twilights, observations, coaching, external conferences and research groups. Unfortunately, this investment does not always bring the intended returns, and “only just over one in ten teachers ‘strongly’ agree that they have taken part in professional development activities that have helped them become better teachers over the last 12 months.”²

The reasons for this are many, and result in the stark observation that **delivering effective CPD is hard**. It’s not that teachers don’t want to change. Teachers welcome effective CPD and, despite their experiences, are often optimistic that it can help them get better at teaching. The problem is that we often treat delivering CPD as a straightforward “I say and they do”, and we do not account for the extensive cultural, psychological and organisational factors that work against meaningful change.

At Carousel Teaching we believe in CPD that helps teachers get better at teaching. We now have years of experience working with teachers and leaders in a range of school contexts, and from this have derived **nine principles that underpin effective CPD** that are outlined in this guide.

This guide does not deal with grand theories of change or leadership. This is not to say that such theories are unimportant or irrelevant, but rather that we are focused here on concrete strategies. The gap between theory and implementation is often underemphasised in the literature on teacher development, and our goal here is to give you simple and readily deployable ideas to use immediately in your school.

Dylan Wiliam is right. All teachers can – and should – get better at teaching. But doing this is hard, and fraught with difficulty. As such, this guide is written to help you get better at leading, so your teachers can get better at teaching.



PRINCIPLE 1

As a leader, ensure you have deep content knowledge

Credibility is built over a long period of time, but it can be destroyed in a day.

Effective delivery of CPD, much like effective classroom teaching, begins with your deep and secure understanding of the content you will deliver. This is essential for two reasons:

- **Effective Contextualisation**

No two schools are the same. A thorough understanding of the material allows you to contextualise the content and plan for its implementation in your school's specific setting. For example, a session focusing on effective lesson starts must consider practical difficulties, such as the challenges faced by teachers who move between classrooms (nomadic teachers), or differing school policies on whether students have their exercise books with them or if they need to be handed out at the start of the lesson. Accounting for these contextual applications with your colleagues is vital. Tailoring the content demonstrates that you have thoughtfully designed the CPD with their specific roles and realities in mind.

- **Establishing Credibility and Buy-in**

Comprehensive knowledge lends authority to the delivery, which is vital for securing staff motivation and buy-in. Before delivering any CPD, you must be able to show colleagues and not just tell them that you have fully grasped the content and its concrete classroom applications. You must practise what you preach, and you should avoid delivering CPD on something that colleagues will not be able to see in action in your own classroom.

Credibility is built over a long period of time, but it can be destroyed in a day. If colleagues think you are asking them to do something that you are unwilling or unable to do yourself, the culture of improvement and development in your school will rapidly deteriorate.



PRINCIPLE 2

Don't overload, and plan your calendar

When planning to improve specific aspects of teaching, like questioning techniques or mini-whiteboard use, you often face the challenge of having a substantial amount of content to deliver. The urge to “cram” information into limited time inevitably results in cognitive overload.

Overloading staff drastically reduces the likelihood of successful implementation and contributes to feelings of demotivation and change fatigue. Furthermore, given the sheer number of things to focus on, leaders cannot effectively support and evaluate the sustained adoption of new practices over the long term.

When planning CPD, you should carefully map out and sequence the content over an extended period. This plan should remain tentative; moving forward to the next session only once you have observed that the changes from the previous one are successfully being adopted in the majority of classrooms.

Within your plans, we recommend structuring individual CPD sessions to have a narrow, clear, and highly practical focus. As a general guide, limit the content of any single session to two or three key strategies at most.

A crucial component of this planning is sequencing the activities that happen between formal sessions. This might involve setting up structures for paired observations, joint lesson planning, or practice activities. Ensure you plan how support will be provided for these activities, especially if they are not yet a normal part of your school's culture.

You should also plan for the specific actions of the leadership team, both senior and middle, in the period immediately following a session. Leadership visibility and support in classrooms after training increases the likelihood of colleagues trialling new strategies. This also provides vital feedback, enabling you to gauge the depth of adoption across your setting.

Below is an example of how a senior leader might plan the implementation of a teaching strategy, providing a model for effective long-term CPD sequencing in your context.

Worked example

Simon, the Teaching and Learning Lead, is planning to implement Carousel Teaching's 'Smashing Your Starter' course. To ensure the new strategies lead to deep and sustainable change, Simon maps out the course delivery over a sustained period, starting with the September INSET and concluding with the January Twilight.

The initial training, Session 1, takes place during September INSET day. The focus is deliberately

narrow, concentrating on just two strategies: that work is readily available for students as they come in the room, and that the type and style of the work is routinised and predictable.

The time between sessions was planned and structured for implementation. Following delivery of the session and throughout September, teachers were asked to film a lesson start focusing only on the two strategies taught. This specific follow-up activity was monitored by Heads of Department and Line Managers who provided non-judgemental feedback and support where appropriate.

Simon also used targeted learning walks during this practice period to observe the adoption of the strategies, identify any emerging implementation barriers, and offer support where required.

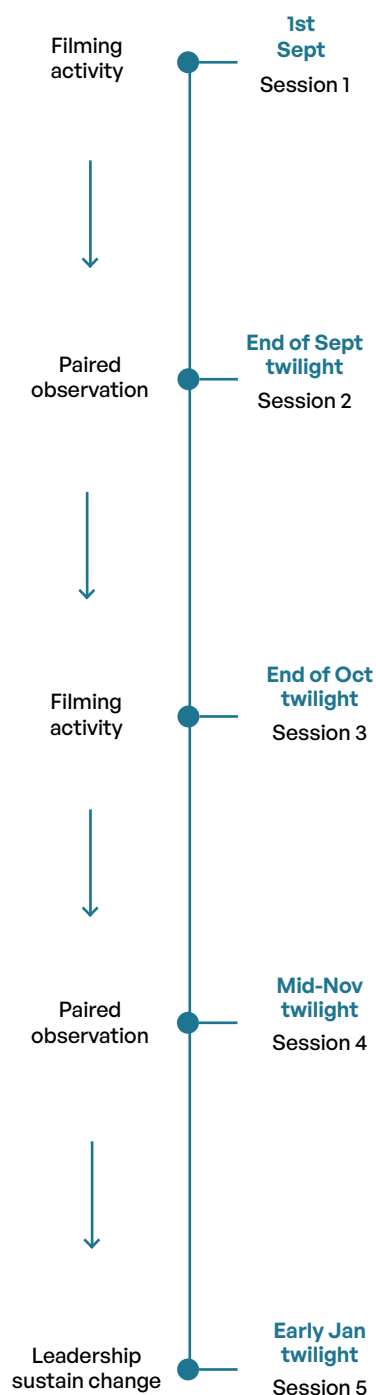
Satisfied that there had been strong adoption of the strategies, Simon planned a Teaching and Learning Twilight session at the end of September to start the next part of the course.

After beginning with a review of prior learning, the session focused on the minutiae of how teachers should stand in the doorway of their classroom at the start of lessons. The follow-up activity was based on videos or paired observations, and learning walks by leaders.

This process was repeated for subsequent twilight sessions throughout October, November, and January, ensuring that no more than three new strategies were introduced at once. There was a strong focus on making the periods in between sessions productive with structured practice, peer observation, and leadership support and refinement. Implementation was monitored through regular developmental learning walks focused only on the specific strategies taught up to that point. The entire course, with its necessary practice and implementation time, concluded in the January twilight.

If, however, Simon had seen that particular strategies were not being implemented by a large number of colleagues, he would have responded differently, and adjusted his plans to go over old material, or use more targeted approaches to increase take-up across the school.

Simon's steady and responsive approach ensured that staff were not overloaded, that practice was structured, and that leadership support was precise and sustained over the long term, promoting deep rather than surface-level change.



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PRINCIPLE 3

Revisit prior learning

Effective professional development requires strengthening long-term memory and ensuring knowledge is readily available for use. Therefore, every new session should begin with a brief review or quiz covering the content from the previous session(s).

Recap quiz



1. What are the two critical prerequisites for an effective lesson start?
2. What is the major purpose of standing in the Threshold as students come into the classroom?
3. What are the four major aims of Regulate Entrants?
4. How have your lesson starts changed as a result of the previous session?

An example recap quiz, taken from Carousel Teaching's Smashing Your Starter course.

Starting your sessions like this carries a number of benefits:

- **Reinforced memory:** It reinforces the strategies and concepts, aiding long-term recall and application by staff.
- **Formative assessment:** It helps you quickly identify common errors in understanding or persistent hurdles in implementation that might require targeted support.
- **Sustained practice:** It embeds a culture that values continuous improvement.
- **Holistic understanding:** It encourages staff to build a cohesive understanding of teaching and learning, rather than seeing each session as isolated.
- **High participation:** As we will see in Principle 5, effective CPD sessions are highly participatory. Ordinarily, staff are used to passivity in CPD sessions, which are often delivered lecture-style, with occasional (if any) opportunities for audience contributions or independent, paired or table work. We advise a much more interactive approach, and starting the session with a quiz sets the tone for this approach at the outset.

When reviewing the quiz, take the opportunity to affirm and congratulate staff on the progress they have made in their knowledge and practice. This positive reinforcement can significantly boost motivation to act upon the training.

Following the session, it is highly likely that content retention will diminish without active support. We advise that you acknowledge the amount of content covered and, to support recall and help prepare staff, summarise the key content and distribute it via email soon after the session concludes. This email should then be re-sent a few days in advance of the subsequent training session. This will ensure that colleagues have enough support to successfully answer the review quiz.

Ensure the email is concise and focused, hitting only the crucial aspects of the session:

Example Summary Email Content

Dear all,

Thank you for your engagement in the session, where we looked at the importance of a strong lesson start. Below is a summary of the content we covered:

A good lesson start is critical for two reasons:

1. We need to maximise learning time, getting students engaged as soon as possible.
2. We set the tone for the entire lesson, influencing subsequent behaviour and thinking.

There are two critical pre-requisites for an effective lesson start:

1. Work is readily available, removing the need for students to search or wait.
2. The work is routinised and consistent in style from lesson to lesson, preventing questions about the task and allowing students to get started without detailed instructions.

This summary covers the key points and should be used to refresh your memory. Please also find details below about the Next Steps activity from the session, along with any relevant deadlines.

Before sending the initial summary, check ahead to ensure the content covered aligns precisely with what you plan to quiz on in the subsequent session.



PRINCIPLE 4

Provide clear, concrete exemplification

A common pitfall of professional development is that it can become overly theoretical, leaving teachers without a clear, actionable understanding of what to do differently in their classrooms the next day.

To deliver effective CPD that results in changed practice, you should therefore ensure that you clearly exemplify what the target strategies look like in the classroom.

Ideally, strategies should be modelled using authentic in-class footage of teachers successfully using the technique, but other options include live modelling the scenario yourself in the session or providing specific verbal scripts.

If you choose to use video examples, ensure your commentary draws colleagues' attention to the most important components, focusing on the nuances that make the strategy effective. For example, in a session about high participation questioning, you might choose a video that allows you to focus on:

- Teacher positioning
- Body language
- Tone of voice
- Precise language used

By highlighting these specific, observable details, you provide colleagues with a concrete reference point, making the transfer of theory into practical classroom action much smoother. Try to direct colleagues away from other questioning considerations (like higher-order questions, open/closed questions etc.) not because they aren't important, but because they aren't important right now. If you want to focus on participation in questioning, don't get bogged down with questions about anything else.

There are technical hurdles to using videos produced in your school. The quality of footage and sound is often not good enough for public display, and you are advised to trial the video to an empty room first to check if the quality meets a professional standard. Despite not being captured in your specific context, curated video libraries like the one in Carousel Teaching can also be an excellent way to demonstrate and model good practice to colleagues.



PRINCIPLE 5

Involve the room

As with effective classroom instruction, professional development should be delivered interactively. If CPD is presented purely as a lecture, colleagues are less likely to remain engaged and the training's impact will diminish. We therefore advise making your session highly interactive to ensure every participant is thinking hard about the new material throughout the session.

In advance of the session, plan the questions you will use throughout. Plan some that are relatively straightforward like definitions and simple applications, and others that are more complex like scenario evaluation. Unpacking scenarios also helps colleagues understand the practical, real-world implications of new teaching strategies, significantly increasing the likelihood that the new content will be retained and implemented.

A scenario



Mr B is about to start his lesson about leaf structure. He wants to check that students can remember what he has previously taught them about plant cells, and one of the questions he asks is:

Which organelle in a plant cell does photosynthesis?

A student calls out "chloroplasts!"

Mr B says:

Yes, that's right. And who can tell me what the products of photosynthesis are...

A scenario from a Carousel Teaching INSET course.

For example, the scenario above allows colleagues to dive into a number of different topics, including the distinction between "review" and "retrieve", the use of verbal response vs mini-whiteboards, and the prevalence and negative effects of calling out. As above, it's worth avoiding getting drawn in to tangential points like the distinction between open and closed questions, or whether we should be calling chloroplasts "organelles" or "sub-cellular structures."

In your bid to increase participation in the session, mini-whiteboards are a simple yet powerful tool. Keep them readily available on desks with sufficient pens for all staff. Mini-whiteboards ensure every colleague is involved and responding, avoiding the likelihood of only hearing from a few staff voices. As per Principle 4: Provide Clear, Concrete Exemplification, if your colleagues are familiar with specific routines (such as 'The Tick Trick' or 'Hover and Show'), you can and should also model the use of these classroom routines within the CPD session itself.



PRINCIPLE 6

Check understanding

Before moving to the application phase of any new strategy, you must ensure colleagues' understanding of it is secure, or you risk poor implementation and misconceptions becoming embedded in practice.

The simplest and most effective way to secure understanding is to build quizzes into your sessions, especially immediately before any activity that requires colleagues to actively plan or apply a new strategy.

Quiz



Which of the below is a correct example of Name At End questioning? Choose as many as you think are correct.

- A. Simon, please give me two characteristics of a stratovolcano.
- B. Name the two products of photosynthesis, Amira – what are the two products of photosynthesis?
- C. Explain what is meant by “line of succession,” David.
- D. On your mini-whiteboards, please give me a quotation from the start of the play that illustrates the political turmoil in Scotland.

A quiz from a Carousel Teaching INSET course.

Skilful writing of multiple-choice distractors allows for rich conversations that both help you assess colleagues' knowledge and deepen their expertise. For example, on one level, the question above allows you to judge whether colleagues understand the principle of 'Name at End' questioning. On another level, it allows you to explore common misconceptions and misapplications, as well as the similarities and differences between 'Name at End' and using mini-whiteboards.



PRINCIPLE 7

Allow dedicated departmental planning time

While many effective teaching strategies such as the 'Name at End' questioning technique have broad application across all subjects, others require subject-specific adaptation.

For instance, if your CPD focuses on how we check student responses for reliability and deep understanding, it is vital to provide dedicated time for individual departments to discuss the kind of questions we could ask. This dedicated planning time is essential because:

- **It addresses subject-specific needs:** Different subjects have different requirements, and our strategies must be tailored to respect each subject's boundaries.
- **Teachers find it more useful:** There is a well-documented desire among teachers for training that is relevant and tailored to their subject context, rather than solely generic.
- **It promotes autonomy and motivation:** Giving staff a measure of autonomy over how they implement the changes can significantly boost intrinsic motivation to execute those changes.
- **It helps colleagues to identify and pre-empt any barriers to implementation:** This significantly increases the chances of successful, sustained change.

We strongly recommend building planning or application tasks into every session you deliver so that colleagues can consider how and when the new strategies will be implemented.



PRINCIPLE 8

Aim for task cohesion across staff

A central purpose of implementing a whole-school CPD programme is to enable staff to share a common professional language and a consistent set of classroom skills. This shared approach is defined as task cohesion³, where members of a team broadly align in their tasks and actions.

It is therefore essential that each CPD session dwells on the collective nature of this improvement effort. The common language and shared strategies should be formulated and communicated not as optional ideas, but as an essential ingredient of how the staff body will work together to improve student outcomes. This doesn't indicate that there is to be no discussion, critique or adaptation. As above, we advocate a model that allows for discussion and debate, but where a final decision and approach is then settled upon and executed.

This cohesion is highly beneficial because, given that pupils benefit from predictability and consistency, many successful teaching approaches are more effective at scale. For example, if all staff members consistently follow common mini-whiteboard routines, it is significantly more likely that students will use them correctly without fuss or disruption. The greater the number of teachers who utilise the same core set of strategies, the better the overall impact on student experience and outcomes.



PRINCIPLE 9

Secure buy-in through quality experience

Start the conversation by asking what experiences colleagues might have had in the past that would lead to them not being bought in.

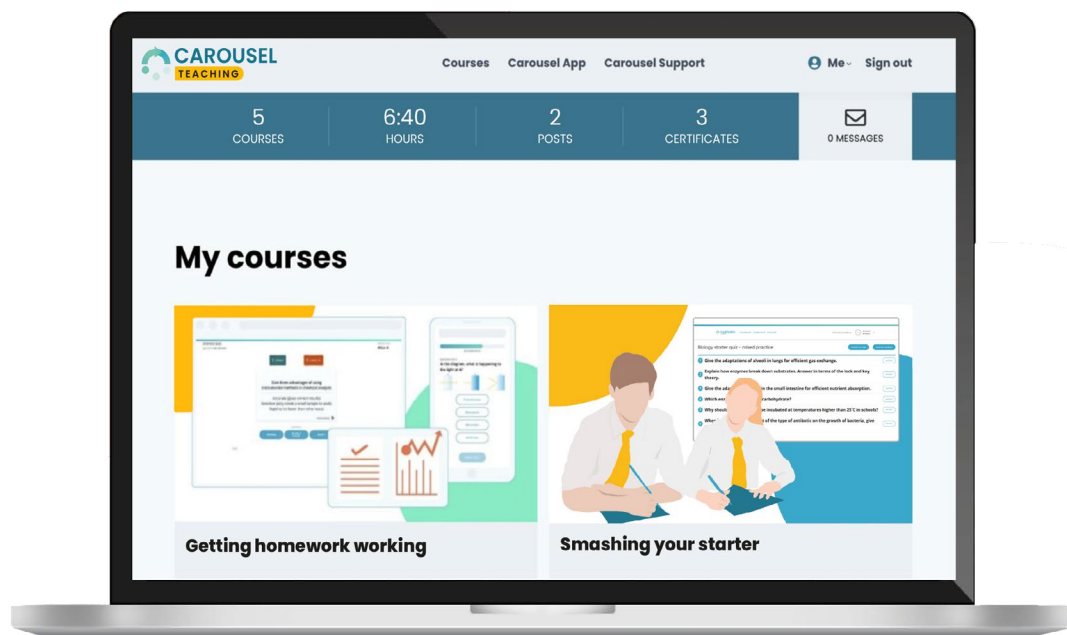
Securing professional buy-in is a frequent area of concern for school leaders. It is important to avoid the assumption that a lack of change in practice is automatically due to teacher reluctance or apathy. Instead, it is worth considering that colleagues may have previously experienced low-quality professional development that failed to incorporate effective principles. CPD is often characterised by a lack of clarity regarding implementation, and by a failure to sequence and pace change. This leads to a sense of frustration and change fatigue in colleagues. It is likely then that these poor prior experiences, rather than personal characteristics, are what lead to justifiable scepticism and low buy-in.

We are often asked for help in securing staff buy-in. We always start the conversation by asking what experiences colleagues might have had in the past that would lead to them not being bought in.

The most effective solution to this is to provide consistently high-quality CPD. By delivering training that adheres to the evidence-based principles outlined in this guide you can dramatically increase the chances of staff engagement and buy-in over the long term.

A further consideration is the practical support required to implement change. For example, if a strategy relies on a specific resource, like mini-whiteboards, you must ensure they are purchased and distributed to all departments before the training session takes place. The same applies to new initiatives around things like behaviour or homework. By considering workload implications and centralisation of escalations, you can give colleagues the support they need to effectively implement the initiative without ill-will.

CONCLUSION



We know that CPD can work, and we know that there is an ethical imperative around teacher improvement. We also know that it isn't easy to get right, and all too often leaders underestimate the work required to ensure the CPD they deliver results in sustainable change. Following the principles outlined in this guide doesn't guarantee that this change will immediately occur in every classroom, but it will help substantially shift the dial in a direction that leads to better teaching.

The Carousel Teaching team values your professional insight. If you have any feedback, suggestions, or require support in applying these principles, please reach out to us by emailing CPD@carousel-learning.com.

To see how we have integrated all these principles into the design of our high-quality CPD platform, we invite you to book a demonstration by visiting carousel-learning.com/teaching. We'd love to show you how we can help you improve the quality of teaching in your setting.

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At Carousel Teaching we believe in CPD that helps teachers get better at teaching. This guide outlines the nine principles that underpin effective CPD.

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Ben Rice is the Head of Professional Development at Carousel. He previously held the roles of Head of Research and Head of History. Ben now works with leaders across the country to implement effective teaching and learning in their schools.

